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The fanciest, most carefully assembled enigma yet put on screen.

Pauline Kael

5001 Nights at the Movies, 1982

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The sense of danger intensifies when the audience learns that a serial killer is on the loose. This revelation comes late in the movie, but Roeg leaves a bread-crumb trail of clues leading up to it: the killer is seen in one of John's photographic slides, hidden in plain sight, in the very first scene; a police inspector doodles a psychotic face as he interviews John at the station. "What is it you fear?" he asks.

The subplot of the murderer adds another layer to the movie's kaleidoscope, forcing the audience to question everything it has seen so far. Is Christine in fact a ghost or something even more sinister? Do



the sisters know more than they are letting on? Eventually, Roeg pulls focus on fate and a truly macabre finale, the kaleidoscope resolving itself into an image of pure Gothic horror.

Closing montage

Roeg saw his movie as an "exercise in film grammar." This is never more evident than in its extraordinary climactic sequence, which begins with a séance and ends with a funeral. *Don't Look Now* forces John to stare death in the face.

The danger of falling is ever present. Laura is taken to hospital after a fall in the restaurant. John is nearly killed in a fall, their son is injured in a fall, and Christine died after falling in the lake.

Finally, in a fog-chilled Venetian chapel, memories come to life and tragedy descends in a queasy flash of horror and recognition. Roeg crowned the movie with a dizzying montage of moments, images, and overlooked clues from the past 108 minutes of story. Much too late, the audience sees everything. ■



Nicolas Roeg Director

Roeg first made his mark as the cinematographer for such cult classics as Roger Corman's *The Masque of the Red Death* (1964) and François Truffaut's *Fahrenheit 451* (1966). In 1970, he teamed up with the writer and painter Donald Cammell to create *Performance*, a gangster movie that starred Mick Jagger as a reclusive rock star. Roeg's next two movies, *Walkabout* (1971) and *Don't Look Now* (1973), continued to explore his fascination with sex, death,

and the complex relationship between time and space. *Don't Look Now* is often referenced by other filmmakers, but Roeg has directed many fascinating movies since, including *The Man Who Fell to Earth* (1976).

Key movies

1970 *Performance*
1971 *Walkabout*
1973 *Don't Look Now*
1976 *The Man Who Fell to Earth*